

For Panasonic, Android is the Way to Go!



Manish Sharma, managing director, Panasonic India

Panasonic, the well known Japanese conglomerate, recently decided to enter the lucrative Indian smartphone market and introduced its first product running on an Android OS. The company had shut down its smartphone business globally, earlier this year, which makes the Indian entry all the more interesting. In an exclusive tete-a-tete with **Open Source For You** magazine, **Manish Sharma, managing director, Panasonic India**, revealed the company's plans for the smartphone scramble and its overall Android product strategy.

Q Panasonic has just made its entry into the smartphone segment in India. What is your take on the strategy and what will the company's focus be?

Our entry into the smartphone segment in India is a well thought-out strategy, unlike many other brands that focus on products for the global environment, targeting global consumers. Panasonic sees India as a huge market and will strive to offer products to the consumers, designed by utilising our extensive technology from Japan and manufacturing capabilities from China. This way, we will be able to deliver the best products at a fast pace to the consumers, which will be our differentiating factor. We are betting big on the Indian market, which is why we are completely focused on offering products that will suit Indian users and weather conditions.

Q Android smartphones are popular in the country, so how do you plan to go about your Android strategy? Do you intend to offer any other platform?

For Panasonic, Android will be the only operating system that we will be using for our products this year. Prior to the P51 smartphone, we had launched a Toughpad tablet that also runs Android. The whole industry is focusing on Android and we will be doing the same as the possibilities with Android are infinite, and we would like to tap this obvious potential in India.

Q After your first India-centric P51 smartphone, how many more products are expected to be launched by Panasonic this year, and what is your target group?

Initially, we will be relying on our hero product, the P51 smartphone, to get the ball rolling. Our extensive marketing strategy will be utilised to enhance the image of the product and brand. From there on, we will introduce another six to seven smartphones by the end of 2013, and these will be priced between Rs 6,999 and Rs 35,000. Most brands are offering close to 60 to 70 products, which is why our roadmap for smartphones going up to the end of this year is not that varied. We intend to offer products that everyone will be able to afford, while taking care of the needs of the mid-segment and high-end consumers also.